

17-inch CRT Monitors

Fifteen-inchers are a thing of the past; the new monitor's minimum starts at 17 inches, thanks to the fall in hardware prices. To go a-monitor shopping, all you need is a little research, some market-browsing and the information you get from the comparison tests that follow.

Features

We had quite a few competitors in the 17-inch category—16 to be precise. The major categorisation here is regular monitors and flat-screen monitors. Flat-screen monitors come in two flavours—Aperture Grille and Shadow Mask. Generally, most of the monitors we use have a picture tube based on Shadow Mask technology. Aperture Grille is a special technology, invented by Sony, and affords greater resolution and clarity.



None of the monitors we received featured integrated speakers. The NEC MultiSync FE791SB and the Samsung 763MB had a special brightness control feature, which adjusts brightness when viewing different types of content: there are preset modes for Internet, text and movie viewing.

All the monitors we received have Shadow Mask picture tubes, except for the NEC MultiSync FE791SB, which has an Aperture Grille tube. The video bandwidth of this monitor, at 145.92 MHz, was the highest amongst all the monitors in the 17-inch category. The NEC monitor also affords the highest resolution, and goes as high as 1,600 x 1,200 at 76 Hz—equivalent to the highest resolutions available on several 19-inch monitors.

Flicker-free viewing is one of the best things about the NEC—the reduction in flicker is because of high refresh rates. The next-best monitors in terms of video bandwidth and features were the LG Flatron E700S and the Samsung 763MB.

Dot pitch is very important when you're considering purchasing a CRT monitor: the smaller the dot pitch, the sharper the image, which translates to improved overall picture quality. The diagonal dot pitch of the NEC is 0.25 mm; however, the Samsung is the best of the lot, with a diagonal dot pitch of 0.23 mm.

Other monitors were run-of-the-mill, with virtually no difference in specifications. It's clear from the features listings

that flat-screen monitors have an edge over regular monitors, with their higher video bandwidth and refresh rates, not to mention the flatness of screen.

Features-wise, the NEC beat the other monitors hands down, but the real tussle was in the performance tests.

Performance

All the monitors we received had OSD (On Screen Display) controls, and we assigned higher scores to those that were user-friendly. The Microtek monitor was particularly so—it has an intuitive interface, with just one knob for all monitor functions. The LG and the Samsung were the other monitors that had very easy-to-use OSD controls. Although the NEC is packed with features, the OSD controls take time to get used to.

Geometry tests were performed to check for monitor symmetry after all adjustments were done. The NEC MultiSync FE791SB was the best of the lot, and scored the highest in the geometry tests. Pincushion distortion is more evident in flat-screen monitors, so the NEC lost out here; however, in the screen regulation tests, it did well.

The NEC monitor seemed to keep its cool where the other monitors were jumpy. A series of 'regulation tests' gauge the monitor using different simulated situations. These are impor-

NEC MultiSync 791SB

The performance winner in this category was hard to beat. Flat screen monitors are better than regular CRTs, and our test results just reinforced the fact.

The NEC MultiSync FE791SB was the only 17-inch monitor in our tests to feature an Aperture Grille CRT. And the advantages are clearly visible. Flicker-free viewing at high resolutions give it a more than enough edge over the other monitors. The diagonal dot pitch of the NEC monitor is also less than 0.26 mm, which, combined with the refresh rates and resolutions, will definitely give you a crisper picture.

The OSD controls could have been more user-friendly, though. The NEC MultiSync FE791SB retails for Rs 16,500, which is way higher than the retail price of any other 17-inch CRT we tested. But quality demands a price, and if you're finicky and won't compromise, you can't go wrong with this monitor.

+ Aperture Grille, flicker-free viewing

– OSD controls not intuitive

Price: Rs 16,500



17" CRT Geometry Test (Out of 25 - Higher the better)

